

Can this trans girl stay on the team?

W.Va. student-athlete goes from track and field meets to Supreme Court

BY JULIAN MARK

Right before Becky Pepper-Jackson sets up to shot put, she always taps her left foot on a board at the edge of the throwing circle.

The ritual helps her focus on her form amid the pressure of the track and field competition — not to mention the additional pressure of spectators wearing T-shirts that say things like “Protect Women’s Sports,” which Pepper-Jackson says are worn specifically for her.

The 15-year-old is the sole transgender student-athlete in West Virginia, according to her attorneys, and her bid to continue playing competitive sports is in the hands of the Supreme Court.

The justices are scheduled to hear arguments Tuesday about whether Pepper-Jackson should continue competing, considering that a state law bans transgender women and girls from playing on women’s sports teams.

“I’m really nervous, obviously,” she said in an interview. “Hopeful — but still nervous.”

Pepper-Jackson’s lawyers argue that the ban discriminates against her for being transgender and violates her constitutional equal-protection rights.

The state counters that the ban is necessary to preserve fairness in women’s sports and that Pepper-Jackson should receive no exceptions. Trans women have an

SEE SUPREME COURT ON A6

Louisiana: Oil company seeks to move case to federal court. **A6**

Border area blames Musk launches for fishing woes

BY TERENCE MCCOY

MATAMOROS, MEXICO — The first time Daniel Santiago saw one of Elon Musk’s super rockets blast off, he thought it was the most magnificent thing he’d ever witnessed — an animalistic roar, a window-shattering tremor, then fire and steel arcing into the skies over Playa Bagdad on Mexico’s northeastern tip.

But then came the next launch, and the one after that, and soon Santiago was broke and fearful of going hungry. Mexican officials and environmentalists warned that the test launches have inflicted ecological damage, and Mexican fishermen like him suspected they were seeing evidence of it out at sea.

By early 2025, community members said, the fish had all but vanished off the coast of Playa Bagdad, just a few miles over the border from Starbase, Texas, where, since April 2023, SpaceX has been testing the world’s largest rocket.

Though scientific research has shown that space launches have resulted in “fish kills” in the past, no causal link has yet been established between the SpaceX launches and the reported disappearance of fish along this stretch

SEE SPACEX ON A18



DEMETRIUS FREEMAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

A renovation of the Federal Reserve’s headquarters in Washington is the subject of a criminal probe disclosed over the weekend.

Regulator pushed to go after Powell

Pulte, who portrayed Fed chair as a ‘wanted’ man, denies any role in probe

BY ANDREW ACKERMAN, NATALIE ALLISON AND SALVADOR RIZZO

Housing finance regulator Bill Pulte met recently with President Donald Trump at Mar-a-Lago and shared a prop resembling a “wanted poster” he had made up featuring Federal Reserve Chair Jerome H. Powell, according to a person with knowledge of the meeting.

Pulte laid out scenarios that included investigating Powell and Trump liked the idea, the person said.

It’s not clear how the inquiry into Powell was approved, but an



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Federal Reserve Board Chair Jerome H. Powell has cast the criminal inquiry as an attack on the Fed’s independence.

official with the Justice Department said it launched a criminal probe into Powell in November and Pulte was not a factor in the inquiry. The extraordinary investigation of a sitting Fed chairman was disclosed by Powell himself late Sunday.

The president on Sunday denied having any prior knowledge of the investigation. White House officials, including press secretary Karoline Leavitt, denied that Trump directed prosecutors to investigate Powell. Trump said in a news conference at Mar-a-Lago on Dec. 29, however, that he was considering legal action against Powell. And as far back as a public appearance in July, Trump raised concerns that the cost of a Fed renovation project was ballooning while touring the construction site with Powell.

And Pulte, an outspoken critic of Powell who oversees the

SEE POWELL ON A12

A young lawmaker comes of age in a grieving city

Somali American state senator’s steady rise in Minn. has been forged in searing local traumas



JOSHUA LOTT/THE WASHINGTON POST

Minnesota state Sen. Zaynab Mohamed, center, talks to her constituents during a protest commemorating Renée Good on Friday at Lake Hiawatha Park in Minneapolis.

BY CAROLINE O'DONOVAN

MINNEAPOLIS — In the volatile hours after an ICE officer shot and killed a woman in her vehicle last week, state Sen. Zaynab Mohamed stood shoulder to shoulder with the chief of police as they moved through the crowd near the scene.

Tensions were high, and both the law enforcement veteran and the woman 18 years his junior were concerned that rippling anger could ignite into something dangerous.

That’s when Chief Brian O’Hara asked Mohamed and the small group of young, female elected officials she was with to help convince the crowd that Minneapolis police weren’t there to work with ICE.

“They’ll listen to you guys,” Mohamed recalled him saying.

Mohamed, 28, is an increasingly high-profile lawmaker with an expanding social media reach whose family fled Somalia nearly 20 years ago in hopes of leaving political violence behind. Over the past half decade, her adopted hometown has suffered searing local traumas that reverberated

SEE MOHAMED ON A8

Justice division left off inquiry

FBI LEADING MINN. SHOOTING PROBE

Civil rights section’s lack of involvement atypical

BY PERRY STEIN

The Justice Department division that regularly handles investigations of police shootings has not been brought into the probe of an immigration officer’s fatal shooting of a woman in Minneapolis, according to multiple people familiar with the matter.

The decision so far to not involve the Civil Rights Division’s criminal section provides a window into the unusual way the Trump administration has handled the investigation. The move has deepened doubts, already raised by Minnesota officials, about whether the shooting will receive a fair and scrupulous examination.

“When you put that together with the state authorities being excluded from even access to the evidence — like shell casings, the car — I don’t have any confidence that a use-of-force investigation is actually even happening when it comes to the death of Renée Good,” said Keith Ellison, the Democratic attorney general of Minnesota.

“I don’t know for certain that they are not doing anything, because they have been amazingly uncommunicative. But they are not telling us what they are doing.”

President Donald Trump, Vice

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Minnesota sues: State alleges DHS’s crackdown is unlawful. **A9**

Top deputy is fired from U.S. attorney office in Va.

BY SALVADOR RIZZO, PERRY STEIN AND STEVE THOMPSON

A veteran prosecutor who was recruited to help run a key U.S. attorney’s office in Virginia was abruptly dismissed last week after disagreements with the Trump administration, according to two people with knowledge of the firing.

Robert K. McBride was first assistant U.S. attorney in the Eastern District of Virginia for about two months, starting after President Donald Trump and his administration purged the top prosecutors in the office and ordered that criminal charges be filed against two of the president’s perceived political opponents, former FBI director James B. Comey and New York Attorney General Letitia James.

McBride had been second-in-command to Lindsey Halligan, the Trump administration lawyer who leads the office but who was disqualified from her position by a judge in late November. His ouster provides the latest sign of upheaval in what has long been regarded as one of the most prestigious U.S. attorney’s offices in the country, and which has seen a raft of firings and resignations

SEE PROSECUTOR ON A9

IN THE NEWS

Regulatory rollback The Environmental Protection Agency said it would no longer consider health care costs resulting from some of the deadliest pollutants. **A5**

Synagogue attack A suspect confessed to setting a fire at a Mississippi house of worship because of its “Jewish ties,” the FBI said. **A7**

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